

Postmortem: INC-2201 - checkout-service Payment Timeout Outage

Sample postmortem document • For ChangeRiskAdvisor RAG corpus • Fictional incident for demo purposes

Summary

On 2026-02-14, a configuration change to checkout-service reduced the payment-gateway call timeout from 5000ms to 500ms. Under normal load this went undetected in staging, but during a promotional traffic spike, the aggressive timeout caused a high rate of false payment failures. Checkout success rate dropped by 42% for approximately 38 minutes before the change was rolled back.

Timeline (UTC)

- 14:02 - Config change deployed to checkout-service via standard release process.
- 14:10 - Promotional campaign email drives a 3x traffic increase.
- 14:15 - Payment failure rate alert fires; on-call engineer begins investigation.
- 14:31 - Root cause identified as the reduced payment-gateway timeout value.
- 14:40 - Change rolled back; payment failure rate returns to baseline within 6 minutes.

Root Cause

The timeout change was classified as a low-risk configuration tweak and did not go through load testing at production traffic levels. checkout-service's dependency on payment-gateway was not flagged as high-risk in the change review, despite two prior incidents (INC-1987, INC-2055) involving the same dependency.

Table 1 below lists the related incident history for the payment-gateway dependency that should have informed this change's risk review.

Incident ID	Service	Date	Severity	Change Type
INC-1987	payment-gateway	2025-09-02	SEV2	Config change
INC-2055	payment-gateway	2025-11-19	SEV1	Dependency upgrade
INC-2201	checkout-service	2026-02-14	SEV1	Config change (this incident)
INC-2214	payment-gateway	2026-03-03	SEV2	Dependency upgrade
INC-2318	payment-gateway	2026-08-15	SEV1	Config change

Impact

Estimated 1,150 checkout attempts failed or were significantly delayed. No data loss occurred. No customer payment information was affected.

Action Items

- Require load testing at 3x baseline traffic for any config change touching payment-gateway timeouts.
- Flag checkout-service and payment-gateway as high-risk services in the change-review process.
- Add automated rollback trigger when checkout success rate drops below 90% for more than 5 minutes.